BUILDING CODE VARIANCE

STANDATA

December 2019

NATURAL GAS REGULATING AND METERING STATION BUILDINGS

PURPOSE

This standata is developed to provide an alternative solution for occupancy classification of high hazard industrial occupancies that house natural gas and metering equipment.

DISCUSSION

High Hazard Industrial Occupancy (Group F, Division 1) is defined by the National Building Code 2019 Alberta Edition (NBC(AE)) as an industrial occupancy containing sufficient quantities of highly combustible and flammable or explosive materials which, because of their inherent characteristics, constitute a special fire hazard.

Buildings containing natural gas regulating and metering equipment are small in size and are designed to provide protection of the equipment. These buildings are not accessible by the public and are only intended for occupancy by employees for maintenance. Such features allow for consideration by a safety codes officer of accepting Group F, Division 2 as an alternative occupancy classification.

CODE REFERENCES

Sentence 6.3.1.6.(1) states:

6.3.1.6. Indoor Air Contaminants
(See Note A-6.3.1.6.)
1) Air contaminants of concern that are released within *buildings* shall
a) be removed insofar as is possible at their points of origin, and
b) not be permitted to accumulate in concentrations greater than those permitted by applicable provincial or territorial requirements or, in the absence of such requirements, by good engineering practice such as that described in the publications listed in Sentence 6.2.1.1.(1), measured using the methodology described therein.

Division A, 1.4.1.2. Defined Terms states:

High-hazard industrial occupancy (Group F, Division 1) means an *industrial occupancy* containing sufficient quantities of highly *combustible* and flammable or explosive materials which, because of their inherent characteristics, constitute a special fire hazard.

Medium-hazard industrial occupancy (Group F, Division 2) means an *industrial occupancy* in which the *combustible* content is more than 50 kg/m^2 or 1 200 MJ/m^2 of *floor area* and not classified as a *high-hazard industrial occupancy*.

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Unless stated otherwise, all Code references in this STANDATA are to Division B of the National Building Code-2019 Alberta Edition.

Issue of this STANDATA is authorized by the Provincial Building Administrator

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VARIANCE

This variance provides approximately equivalent or greater safety performance with respect to persons and property as that provided for by the Safety Codes Act and the NBC(AE).

Buildings used to house natural gas regulating and metering equipment may be classified as Group F, Division 2 occupancy provided:

1. The building does not exceed 55 m^2 in building area or one storey in building height,
2. The building is considered as a low human occupancy building, and
3. Sufficient ventilation is available as per Sentence 6.3.1.6.(1) so that any small leaks from fittings will not accumulate and there is a constant movement of air.

This VARIANCE is applicable throughout the province of Alberta.

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